

33rd

ANNIVERSARY
SPECIAL

RECORDING the Heartbeat of History

By Dilip Bobb

The public have an insatiable curiosity to know everything. Except what is worth knowing. Journalism, conscious of this, supplies their demands —Oscar Wilde

We have occupied a front row seat to history as it unfolded “in its timeless procession of laughter and tears, courage and cowardice, good and evil...” It’s a seat we have occupied for 33 tumultuous years and that is long enough to say we’ve been there, done that and earned the T-shirt. Whether it is mere coincidence or a country’s karma, we were born in a time of crisis and celebrate our anniversary in the midst of one. On December 15, 1975, when INDIA TODAY first appeared in a more humble avatar, we were in the suffocating grasp of the Emergency. In 2008, our anniversary celebrations are dampened by the darkening shadow of terror.

Both those events were extreme, one the work of a ruthless but insecure leader, the other, mindless and insane, but symbolic of the most serious challenge India faces. Both were, and are, understandably enough, media oxygen. The Emergency was Indian democracy’s darkest hour but also a time when the magazine established itself. Once the Emergency was lifted, in March 1977, the untold stories tumbled out of the political closets, and a brand, later an institution, was born. We truly, as Dickens wrote, lived in the worst of times, the best of times. For us, it is a print-smudged blur but the pages that follow give some idea of the turbulence we have lived through as a nation, and covered as a magazine. India is an endless ‘Breaking News’ story, and its triumphs and tragedies, politicians and personalities, scandals and sensations have

given us a script worthy of an epic.

The Gandhis dominated, as befitting the world’s most enduring dynasty, as did, literally, Amitabh Bachchan, now creating a dynasty of his own in film-dom. Coalitions created instability and dealmakers while communalism and bigotry often undercut our credentials as a secular democracy, but we survived, and thrived. India’s economic growth post-1991 is a miracle considering the odds but it changed the face of the country, and expanded media coverage into areas we had not anticipated. Flash weddings, designer boutiques, Page 3 personalities, millionaire mansions and entrepreneurship in fast forward mode. It showed what a people unshackled from socialism and bureaucratic inertia were capable of.

The media itself has expanded beyond recognition, now a frenetic 24/7 kaleidoscope of instant images and views. It is a mirror of Indian democracy; chaotic, competitive, often disturbing but often uplifting. Thirty-three years on, India remains a work in progress and our coverage reflected that in graphic detail. Finally, out of the fog of history, has emerged an idea of India, and that is progress enough. Yet, we also have the largest number of people living in poverty, over 260 million.

That too is India. Contrasts and contradictions are in our DNA, as are the challenges, from institutionalised corruption to systemic flaws in governance and the bureaucracy. Yet, dramatic change has come in 33 years, incremental and painfully slow but much of it positive and forward-looking. So too has a sense of purpose and unity, especially after the Mumbai attacks. All we need in a common slogan, a mantra that can push us to greater and more lasting achievements. It is a Barack Obama patent, but it will do us just fine. ‘Yes we can’.